

Connecticut State Department of Education

DISTRICT PROFILE AND PERFORMANCE REPORT FOR SCHOOL YEAR 2023–24



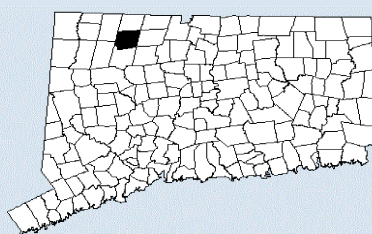
Explorations District

Jill Johnson, Charter School Principal or Director • 860-738-9070 • <http://www.ExplorationsCS.com>

District Information

Grade Range	9-12
Number of Schools/Programs	1
Enrollment	88
Per Pupil Expenditures ¹	\$19,146
Total Expenditures ¹	\$1,780,565

¹ Expenditure data reflect the 2022-23 school year.



Community Information

AdvanceCT Town Profiles provide summary demographic and economic information for Connecticut's municipalities at <https://www.advancect.org/site-selection/town-profiles>

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Notes

Unless otherwise noted, all data are for 2023-24 and include all grades offered by the district.

In most tables, data are displayed only for the three major race/ethnicity categories. For additional race/ethnicity categories, please visit <https://edsight.ct.gov>

State totals are not displayed as they are not comparable to district totals.

Special Education tables reflect only students for whom the district is fiscally responsible.

* When an asterisk is displayed, data have been suppressed to safeguard student confidentiality. Complete data suppression guidelines are available at <https://tinyurl.com/SuppressionPolicy>

N/A is displayed when a category is not applicable for a district or school.

Students

October 1, 2023 Enrollment²

	District		State
	Count	Percent of Total (%)	Percent of Total (%)
Female	46	52.3	48.3
Male	*	*	51.5
Non-Binary	*	*	0.1
American Indian or Alaska Native	0	0.0	0.2
Asian	0	0.0	5.2
Black or African American	*	*	12.5
Hispanic or Latino of any race	16	18.2	31.1
Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander	0	0.0	0.1
Two or More Races	*	*	4.7
White	60	68.2	46.2
English Learners/Multilingual Learners	*	*	10.5
Eligible for Free or Reduced-Price Meals	56	63.6	44.0
Students with Disabilities ³	29	33.0	17.9

² This table represents students in grades PK-12 reported by the district in the Public School Information System (i.e., PSIS Reporting District).

³ Students in this category are students with an individualized education program (IEP) only. This category does not include students with Section 504 plans or services plans.

Chronic Absenteeism and Suspension/Expulsion

	Chronic Absenteeism ⁴		Suspension/Expulsion ⁵	
	Count	Rate (%)	Count	Rate (%)
Female	14	40.0	*	*
Male	*	*	*	*
Non-Binary	*	*	*	*
Black or African American	*	*	0	*
Hispanic or Latino of any race	*	*	*	*
White	19	38.0	*	*
English Learners/Multilingual Learners	0	*	0	*
Eligible for Free or Reduced-Price Meals	17	37.0	*	*
Students with Disabilities	7	26.9	*	*
District	28	37.3	*	*
State		17.7		7.0

Number of students qualified as truant under state statute: 21

Number of school-based arrests: Fewer than 6

⁴ A student is chronically absent if they miss ten percent or greater of the total number of days enrolled in the school year for any reason. Pre-Kindergarten students are excluded from this calculation.

⁵ This column displays the count and percentage of students who receive at least one in-school suspension, out-of-school suspension or expulsion.

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Educators

Full-Time Equivalent (FTE)¹ Staff

	FTE
General Education	
Teachers and Instructors	8.1
Paraprofessional Instructional Assistants	0.0
Special Education	
Teachers and Instructors	2.0
Paraprofessional Instructional Assistants	1.0
Administrators, Coordinators and Department Chairs	
District Central Office	0.5
School Level	2.0
Library/Media	
Specialists (Certified)	0.0
Support Staff	0.0
Instructional Specialists Who Support Teachers	0.0
Counselors, Social Workers and School Psychologists	0.0
School Nurses	1.0
Other Staff Providing Non-Instructional Services/Support	3.5

¹ In the full-time equivalent count, staff members working part-time in the school are counted as a fraction of full-time. For example, a teacher who works half-time in a school contributes 0.50 to the school's staff count.

Educators by Race/Ethnicity

	Count	District Percent of Total (%)	State Percent of Total (%)
American Indian or Alaska Native	0	0.0	0.1
Asian	0	0.0	1.4
Black or African American	0	0.0	4.8
Hispanic or Latino of any race	0	0.0	5.1
Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander	0	0.0	0.1
Two or More Races	1	7.1	0.3
White	13	92.9	88.3

Classroom Teacher Attendance: 2022-23

	District	State
Average Number of FTE Days Absent Due to Illness or Personal Time	8.6	13.3

Instruction and Resources

11th and 12th Graders Enrolled in College-and-Career-Readiness Courses during High School²

	11th		12th	
	Count	Rate (%)	Count	Rate (%)
Black or African American	*	*	0	*
Hispanic or Latino of any race	*	*	*	*
White	13	*	*	*
English Learners/Multilingual Learners	N/A	N/A	N/A	N/A
Eligible for Free or Reduced-Price Meals	13	*	*	*
Students with Disabilities	9	*	*	*
District	20	87.0	14	*
State		88.4		94.6

² College-and-Career-Readiness Courses include Advanced Placement®(AP), International Baccalaureate®(IB), Career and Technical Education(CTE), workplace experience and dual credit courses.

Students Who Spend 80% or Greater Time with Nondisabled Peers³

	Count	Rate (%)
Autism	N/A	N/A
Emotional Disability	N/A	N/A
Intellectual Disability	N/A	N/A
Learning Disability	N/A	N/A
Other Health Impairment	N/A	N/A
Other Disabilities	N/A	N/A
Speech/Language Impairment	N/A	N/A
District	N/A	N/A
State		66.8

³ This table represents students ages 6-21 for whom the district is fiscally responsible (i.e., Nexus District students with an IEP or services plan).

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Students with Disabilities by Primary Disability¹

	District		State
	Count	Rate (%)	Rate (%)
Autism	N/A	N/A	2.6
Emotional Disability	N/A	N/A	1.1
Intellectual Disability	N/A	N/A	0.6
Learning Disability	N/A	N/A	6.4
Other Health Impairment	N/A	N/A	3.5
Other Disabilities	N/A	N/A	1.2
Speech/Language Impairment	N/A	N/A	2.0
All Disabilities	N/A	N/A	17.3

¹ This table represents students in grades K-12 for whom the district is fiscally responsible (i.e., Nexus District students with an IEP or services plan).

Students with Disabilities Placed Outside of the District²

	District		State
	Count	Rate (%)	Rate (%)
Public Schools in Other Districts	N/A	N/A	8.0
Private Schools or Other Settings	N/A	N/A	4.6

² This table represents students in grades K-12 for whom the district is fiscally responsible (i.e., Nexus District students with an IEP or services plan).

Overall Expenditures³: 2022-23

	Total (\$)	Per Pupil	
		District (\$)	State (\$)
Instruction	\$784,611	\$8,437	\$12,942
Support services - students	\$209,448	\$2,252	\$1,724
Support services - instruction	\$20,296	\$218	\$905
Support services - general administration	\$50,205	\$540	\$520
Support services - school based administration	\$425,076	\$4,571	\$1,207
Central and other support services	.	.	\$771
Operation and maintenance of plant	\$252,829	\$2,719	\$2,101
Student transportation services	\$38,100	\$1,089	\$1,582
Food services	.	.	\$8
Enterprise operations	.	.	\$213
Total	\$1,780,565	\$19,146	\$21,143

³ Expenditures may be supported by local tax revenues, state grants, federal grants, municipal in-kind services, tuition and other sources.

Special Education Expenditures: 2022-23

	District		State
	Total (\$)	Percent of Total (%)	Percent of Total (%)
Teacher Salaries	\$200,553	71.0	27.6
Instructional Aide Salaries	.	.	10.2
Other Salaries	\$59,718	21.2	10.5
Employee Benefits	\$22,034	7.8	13.2
Purchased Services Other Than Transportation	.	.	6.4
Special Education Tuition	.	.	22.2
Supplies	.	.	0.7
Property Services	.	.	0.4
Purchased Services For Transportation	.	.	8.4
Equipment	.	.	0.3
All Other Expenditures	.	.	0.1
Total	\$282,305	100.0	100.0
Percent of Total Expenditures Used for Special Education		15.9	25.0

Expenditures by Revenue Source⁴: 2022-23

	Percent of Total (%) Excluding School Construction
Local	15.9
State	61.0
Federal	7.0
Tuition & Other	16.1

⁴ Revenue sources do not include state-funded Teachers' Retirement Board contributions, Connecticut Technical Education and Career System (CTECS) operations, CSDE-budgeted costs for salaries and leadership activities and other state-funded school districts (e.g., Dept. of Children and Families and Dept. of Correction).

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Performance and Accountability

District Performance Index (DPI)

A District Performance Index (DPI) is the average performance of students in a subject area (i.e., ELA, Mathematics or Science) on the state summative assessments. The DPI ranges from 0-100. A DPI is reported for all students tested in a district and for students in each individual student group. Connecticut's ultimate target for a DPI is 75.

	English Language Arts (ELA)		Math		Science	
	Count	DPI	Count	DPI	Count	DPI
American Indian or Alaska Native	0	N/A	0	N/A	0	N/A
Asian	0	N/A	0	N/A	0	N/A
Black or African American	*	*	*	*	*	*
Hispanic or Latino of any race	6	*	6	*	6	*
Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander	0	N/A	0	N/A	0	N/A
Two or More Races	*	*	*	*	*	*
White	12	*	12	*	10	*
English Learners/Multilingual Learners	0	N/A	0	N/A	0	N/A
Non-English Learners/Non-Multilingual Learners	21	38.8	21	32.0	18	*
Eligible for Free or Reduced-Price Meals	13	*	13	*	11	*
Not Eligible for Free or Reduced-Price Meals	8	*	8	*	7	*
Students with Disabilities	*	*	*	*	*	*
Students without Disabilities	*	*	*	*	*	*
High Needs	14	*	14	*	12	*
Non-High Needs	7	*	7	*	6	*
District	21	38.8	21	32.0	18	*

National Assessment of Educational Progress (NAEP): Percent At or Above Proficient¹

	NAEP 2022		NAEP 2013
	Grade 4	Grade 8	Grade 12
READING			
Connecticut	35	35	50
National Public	32	29	36
MATH			
Connecticut	37	30	32
National Public	35	26	25

¹ NAEP is often called the "Nation's Report Card." It is sponsored by the U.S. Department of Education. This table compares Connecticut's performance to that of national public school students. Performance standards for state assessments and NAEP are set independently. Therefore, one should not expect performance results to be the same across Smarter Balanced and NAEP. Instead, NAEP results are meant to complement other state assessment data. To view performance on NAEP by student group, at https://portal.ct.gov/-/media/SDE/Student-Assessment/NAEP/report-card_NAEP-2022.pdf

Physical Fitness Tests: Students Reaching Health Standard²

	Percent of Students by Grade ³ (%)				All Tested Grades	
	4	6	8	HS	Count	Rate (%)
Sit & Reach	N/A	N/A	N/A	*	17	*
Curl Up	N/A	N/A	N/A	*	17	*
Push Up	N/A	N/A	N/A	*	17	*
Mile Run/PACER	N/A	N/A	N/A	*	17	*
All Tests - District	N/A	N/A	N/A	*	17	*
All Tests - State	53.6	48.4	44.6	42.3		47.2

²The Connecticut Physical Fitness Assessment (CPFA) is administered to students in Grades 4, 6, 8 and High School (HS). The health-related fitness scores gathered through the CPFA should be used to educate and motivate children and their families to increase physical activity and develop lifetime fitness habits.

³Only students assessed in all four areas are included in this calculation.

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Cohort Graduation: Four-Year¹

	2022-23	
	Cohort Count ²	Rate (%)
Black or African American	N/A	N/A
Hispanic or Latino of any race	*	*
White	31	64.5
English Learners/Multilingual Learners	N/A	N/A
Eligible for Free or Reduced-Price Meals	33	*
Students with Disabilities	17	*
District	37	56.8
State		88.4

¹ The four-year cohort graduation rate represents the percentage of first-time 9th graders who earn a standard high school diploma within four years.

² Cohort count includes all students in the cohort as of the end of the 2022-23 school year.

11th and 12th Graders Demonstrating Postsecondary Readiness³

	Count	Rate (%)
Female	0	*
Male	*	*
Non-Binary	*	*
Black or African American	0	*
Hispanic or Latino	*	*
White	*	*
English Learners/ Multilingual Learners	N/A	N/A
Eligible for Free or Reduced-Price Meals	0	0.0
Students with Disabilities	*	*
District	*	*
State		44.3

³Students demonstrate postsecondary readiness through at least one of the following:

- SAT® - meets benchmark score on SAT, Revised SAT or Connecticut School Day SAT
- ACT® - meets benchmark score on 3 of 4 exams (benchmark score varies by subject)
- AP® - 3 or higher on any one AP® exam
- IB® - 4 or higher on any one IB® exam
- Earning three or more non-remedial college credits cumulatively during high school.

Sources:

SAT® and AP® statistics derived from data provided by the College Board.

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ACT® statistics derived from data provided by ACT, Inc.

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IB® statistics derived from data provided by the International Baccalaureate Organization.

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College Entrance and Persistence

	Class of 2023	Class of 2022
	Entrance ⁵ Rate (%)	Persistence ⁶ Rate (%)
Female	*	*
Male	*	*
Non-Binary	N/A	*
Black or African American	N/A	N/A
Hispanic or Latino of any race	*	*
White	*	*
English Learners/ Multilingual Learners	N/A	N/A
Eligible for Free or Reduced-Price Meals	*	*
Students with Disabilities	*	*
District	47.8	*
State	68.4	87.2

⁵ College entrance refers to the percent of high school graduates from the year who enrolled in college any time during the first year after high school.

⁶ College persistence refers to the percent of students who enrolled in college the first year after high school and returned for a second year (Freshman to Sophomore persistence).

Source: National Student Clearinghouse

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Next Generation Accountability Results

Connecticut's Next Generation Accountability System is a broad set of 12 indicators that help tell the story of how well a district/school is preparing its students for success in college, careers, and life. It moves beyond test scores and graduation rates to provide a more holistic, multifactor perspective of district and school performance.

Indicator		Index/Rate	Target	Points Earned	Max Points	% Points Earned	State Average Index/Rate
ELA Performance Index	All Students	38.8	75	77.7	150	51.8	63.9
	High Needs Students	.	75	.	.	.	54.1
Math Performance Index	All Students	32.0	75	63.9	150	42.6	60.2
	High Needs Students	.	75	.	.	.	49.5
Science Performance Index	All Students	.	75	.	.	.	61.8
	High Needs Students	.	75	.	.	.	51.4
ELA Academic Growth	All Students	.	100%	.	.	.	58.7%
	High Needs Students	.	100%	.	.	.	54.2%
Math Academic Growth	All Students	.	100%	.	.	.	61.4%
	High Needs Students	.	100%	.	.	.	55.1%
Progress Toward English Proficiency	Literacy	.	100%	.	.	.	58.9%
	Oral	.	100%	.	.	.	55.2%
Chronic Absenteeism	All Students	37.3%	<=5%	0.0	50	0.0	17.7%
	High Needs Students	35.2%	<=5%	0.0	50	0.0	25.5%
Preparation for CCR	% Taking Courses	85.0%	75%	50.0	50	100.0	91.5%
	% Meeting Benchmark	10.0%	75%	6.7	50	13.3	44.3%
On-track to High School Graduation		.	94%	.	.	.	84.5%
4-year Graduation All Students (2023 Cohort)		56.8%	94%	60.4	100	60.4	88.4%
6-year Graduation - High Needs Students (2021 Cohort)		.	94%	.	.	.	86.6%
Postsecondary Entrance (Class of 2023)		47.8%	75%	63.7	100	63.7	68.4%
Physical Fitness (estimated part rate) and (fitness rate)		81.0% 23.5%	75%	7.8	50	15.7	93.6% 47.2%
Arts Access		38.7%	60%	32.2	50	64.4	55.0%
Accountability Index				362.4	800	45.3	

NOTE: A dot (.) appears in the table above when there are fewer than 20 students in the student group or the indicator is not applicable based on grades served.

Gap Indicators	Non-High Needs Rate ¹	High Needs Rate	Size of Gap	State Gap Mean +1 Stdev ²	Is Gap an Outlier? ²
Achievement Gap Size Outlier?					N
ELA Performance Index Gap	.	.	.	16.9	
Math Performance Index Gap	.	.	.	18.2	
Science Performance Index Gap	.	.	.	17.9	
Graduation Rate Gap	.	.	.	.	

¹If the Non-High Needs Rate exceeds the ultimate target (75 for Performance Index and 94% for graduation rate), the ultimate target is used for gap calculations.

²If the size of the gap exceeds the state mean gap plus one standard deviation, the gap is an outlier.

NOTE: A dot (.) appears in the table above when there are fewer than 20 students in at least one of the student groups used to calculate the gap measure or the indicator is not applicable based on grades served. Gap calculations are based on unrounded rates.

Subject/Student Group		Participation Rate (%) ³
ELA	All Students	78.6
	High Needs Students	75.0
Math	All Students	78.6
	High Needs Students	75.0
Science	All Students	79.2
	High Needs Students	.

³Minimum participation standard is 95%.

Connecticut's State Identified Measurable Result (SIMR) for Children with Disabilities

Increase the reading performance of all 3rd grade students with disabilities statewide, as measured by Connecticut's English Language Arts (ELA) Performance Index.

Grade 3 ELA Performance Index for Students with Disabilities:

District: N/A

State: 49.7

District Profile and Performance Report for School Year 2023-24

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Narratives

School District Improvement Plans and Parental Outreach Activities

During the 2023-24 school year, students attended Explorations from 15 different towns and staff found many students had academic deficiencies in basic skills. We used classroom formative tests and benchmark STAR 360 three times during the year to identify students in need of additional support and measure growth over time. Teachers had access to data from benchmark testing for all students to use as they planned lessons, created IEP goals, and created classroom Focus Areas. Teachers continued to revise curriculum to better differentiate and meet the needs of all students. Students showing a weakness in Math received increased Math Lab support in addition to their scheduled math class. In staff meetings, staff discussed student specific needs and planned how best to accommodate them in the classroom.

To increase student engagement, students and staff planned activities to engage students and the school community, such as spirit week. This year, students and staff dressed up for various themes, such as Dress-To-Impress, Twin Day and Decades Day, culminating in a Halloween Costume contest.

To curb student truancy, we continued a policy where parents were contacted daily by our school nurse and automated system when students were absent. The contact with parents allowed us to have important conversations around attendance. The school Executive Director, assistant principal, social worker, nurse, and one special education teacher worked as members of the achievement committee. The group refined the process to identify and support student truancy; these included earlier intervention strategies, revised letters, student conferences, parent meetings, and referrals to outside agencies. The social worker addressed a range of social-emotional issues, and worked closely with families, teachers, and administration to implement strategies and work on goals related to student IEPs and social-emotional needs. The school nurse and assistant principal also held almost daily meetings to offer support to students and to find ways to improve their grades in the classroom, daily attendance, and to listen to any concerns.

We continued our commitment to supporting the family's role in the education of our students. The "Parent Portal" through Rediker Software allowed parents and students to check grades in all classes in real time, providing transparency and increased communication between parents and staff. We held a family pasta dinner in the spring that was very well attended, and we look forward to bringing this annual tradition back twice a year. We held a variety of virtual and in-person parent conferences and continued to work with families to ensure that students had access to necessary resources, technology, and connectivity. Parents could come to the school building to pick up necessary supplies. When transportation posed a challenge for parents, administrators and staff delivered required items to student homes. Staff regularly communicated with parents to offer support and guidance on helping their students.

Explorations also started an Enrollment Committee (made of administrators, teachers, and support staff) to revise the school application, brochures, and recruitment practices. The hope is to attract more students to the school and to form stronger connections with sending districts.

Efforts to Reduce Racial, Ethnic and Economic Isolation

The school provides opportunities for teachers and students to gain awareness of diversity, differences, and personal experiences through our curriculum. This multi-cultural lens helps students form personal connections and reflect on acquired knowledge. The school is welcoming of all races, backgrounds, and sexual orientations; students are free to be themselves and are accepted. For the second year, Explorations offered the CSDE created Black and Latin studies class to 15 students and we plan to run a full class again in 2024-2025.

The location of Explorations in the northwestern corner limits more diverse communities from taking advantage of our school. We placed ads on local radio stations and newspapers, but did not travel to other schools in 2023-24. We hope, through the work of our school guidance counselor, to partner with schools in 2024-2025 to reintroduce our school program.

We hosted a Spring Enrollment Open house that was very well attended and nearly every family that attended submitted an application for admission. To help our relative geographic isolation, we provide transportation with three bus stops in Torrington for students at a significant expense to our budget.

Our Friday activities offer unique opportunities for our students. Adventure Education takes the place of the standard PE classes with activities including ice skating, biking, kayaking, and hiking. Many geographically isolated students from lower socio-economic backgrounds have never participated in these types of activities; for some, this creates a lifelong interest.

All students grades students also experience "Academic Enrichment Fridays"; topics include guidance (including College and Career prep), health, fitness, SAT/NGSS Prep, team building, and remedial and enrichment activities. This year, juniors and seniors also participated in a Friday building rotation. The students covered similar topics with an additional focus on writing resumes and college entrance essays, work safety training, and job interview skills.

Our minority population increased over the past 10 years from 9.6% in June, 2014 to 33.3% in June, 2024.

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Equitable Allocation of Resources among District Schools

As a one building charter school, Explorations allocates all resources in one high school building. The proposed budget of our school is created in late spring by administrators and the board finance committee, voted on by the Governing Board, and is based on full enrollment and funding from the SDE. Adjustments are made after the October 1 count as needed. Grant writing is the greatest supplement to our budget, and we use grants for student and staff need areas. Title I, Title II and Title IV funds are allocated to support programs to support all students. Parents are also essential to aiding our overhead costs. They often provide the school with a variety of products, including paper towels, toilet paper, classroom supplies, and copy paper. Our solar panel project, completed with grant funds in 2019, continues to provide savings on school energy bills as well as enhancing opportunities for integrated units within the Science curriculum.